

Discord Redesign Phase 2

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Abstract— Over the past eight years since its initial release date, Discord has become a prevalent communication social platform in which countless people use on a daily basis. The main functionalities of Discord include instant messaging, voice calls, and video calls for individuals and groups. The main task that I will be discussing involves Discord's group voice channels for group users.

1 PARTICIPANT OBSERVATION

The participant observation in this needfinding exercise was performed over specific steps that were recreated in multiple environments to accumulate data that could be affected by the context that I would be in.

1.1 Results

These raw results varied depending on the context that I was in as well as how well I was able to complete the task. The results include notes, thoughts, and any other possible points that can contribute to the conclusions from this needfinding exercise. The task is simply to complete a call utilizing the Discord group voice channel.

1.1.1 *Discord at Home*

- Following steps does not cause any issue
- Does not have substantial notification when joining a call

1.1.2 *Discord at Office*

- Discord is disruptive when used in a quiet setting, requires headset to not disrupt others
- Difficult to join and leave call when on another screen

1.1.3 *Discord on Mobile*

- Interface has additional page to join voice channel
- Better flow in showing how to join and leave voice channel

- Difficult to maneuver through Discord after joining call

1.1.4 *Discord on Mobile while exercising*

- Difficult to follow steps while focus is split on another task

1.2 Takeaways

The conclusions that were drawn from this needfinding plan were very concrete. Since I was constantly focused on observing how the task was completed and how all factors were affecting the situation, I was able to determine that environmental factors and which device used in the use of Discord's group voice channel causes the user to have different experiences with the interface. What I experienced was that Discord's group channel interface allowed for computer utilization to be more difficult than mobile. The mobile interface gives the user much better explanations in its use and how to properly complete the task of joining and leaving a voice channel. However, this conflicts with the environmental factors that the user may be in. When I was using Discord's voice channel at home or in the office, I did not have issues of Discord interfering with any other tasks that I was involved in.

1.3 Bias control

Although I knew that confirmation bias was going to be an issue that participant observation, I believe that confirmation bias was effectively able to be combatted. The confirmation bias was mitigated through the thorough breakdown of the procedure I created to complete the task. Each step was broken down so that even a new Discord user should be able to follow the procedures. In addition, during the process of the observation, I would make sure to take notes entirely on what I observed and how I felt in the moment. This did not allow my bias of being an experienced Discord user and my opinions of Discord to affect how the participation was completed.

2 SURVEYS

This needfinding plan utilizes surveys to be able to gather data from a group of users of Discord. The survey itself does not elicit any specific issues about Discord to be able to determine whether or not the interface's voice group channels are truly difficult for users to utilize.

2.1 Results

The raw data of the results can be seen in the appendix. However, to go over the results, the users of Discord mainly utilize the application for gaming and social communication. This meant that group voice channels would be a main feature that they would be using. The answers from the survey specified that the users mainly use other applications such as Zoom and Microsoft Teams for work and school, while use Discord for leisure. The issues that were mentioned that the application had revolved around two points of audio issues and the use of the call feature. Both of these points can be seen as one main issue of user friendliness of Discord. Despite these issues, Discord had a consistently high rating from the surveyees and very little improvements mentioned.

2.2 Takeaways

The results of the survey clearly shows despite Discords having high satisfaction ratings, the learning curve of Discord is an issue in its new users. Most of the issues that were mentioned by users using Discord for the first time revolved around not understanding how the features work or how to set up Discord properly.

2.3 Bias Control

Observer bias is the most likely bias that can arise from surveys, which can be found in the phrasing of the questions. Social desirability bias, voluntary response bias, and recall bias are also among other types of bias that can be an issue for this survey. To resolve observer bias and social desirability bias, my survey questions were carefully worded to not elicit any type of specific response. In addition, the questions were reviewed by another person outside of the needfinding. The survey itself is designed to allow the user to give their unaffected opinions of Discord and its features. Unfortunately, voluntary response bias and recall bias were not controlled as properly as well as the other biases. Since my survey was completely open to multiple users on different forums and it was not required, only people who had a truly strong opinion about Discord would more likely respond. A possible way that I could have done to mitigate this is to have a more selective way of gathering participants in the survey and reducing the leakage of the topic of the survey so that not only people with more aggressive opinions on the topic will take the survey. Recall bias could have been mitigated as well by having the user go through the steps I

used in the participant observation for them to recall his or her use of Discord before completing the survey. This will help users not answer the questions on possibly old memories that might not be as accurate as if they would have done the task recently.

3 ANALYSIS OF REVIEWS

To be able to compare Discord to another application with group voice features, I decided to analyze reviews of Discord and Zoom on “getapp.com”. This needfinding exercise allows me to put Discord and one of its greatest competitors side by side and draw conclusions from the data.

3.1 Results

The results of both Discord and Zoom will be shown based on the accumulation of 3 overall topics that I determined were defining for the application that were drawn from the extensive reviews.

3.1.1 *Discord*

- User-friendliness/Ease of use: Based on the numerous reviews, Discord’s user friendliness can be considered decently high. However, there are a fair amount of users that display an issue with its learning curve. Most negative reviews revolve around the issue of not understanding how to use Discord when first utilizing it.
- Features: The reviews about Discord have shown quite positive feedback based on the many different features it has overall. However, this also comes with its own drawbacks where users are not able to understand how to fully utilize all of its different features.
- Continuation of use: Most reviewers have been shown to either use Discord daily over the span of months to years or they utilize Discord weekly.

3.1.2 *Zoom*

- User-friendliness/Ease of use: Reviews have shown that Zoom’s ease of use is consistently high. Most users have no issues with learning how and continuing to use Zoom.

- Features: The features that Zoom offers have a good average of high reviews. However, this is balanced out with many reviews that are concerned with the bugs and connection issues that Zoom tends to have.
- Continuation of use: Zoom's use for its reviewers are heavily favoring weekly use. Although there are a large number of users who use it daily as well.

3.2 Takeaways

The comparison between Discord and Zoom has led me to a few very distinct conclusions. Although both applications offer group voice calls, Discord has many other features in addition to this feature, while Zoom mainly highlights this singular feature. Although this causes Discord's ease of use to drop and Zoom's user friendliness to rise, Discord does not have any problems with the interface not working properly. Zoom on the other hand has many problems with the actual use of the interface to complete the task. Both applications have a strong user base where many people use them daily and weekly, however, Zoom tends to have a higher number of users due to its user friendliness and quick learning curve.

3.3 Bias Control

Voluntary response bias and confirmation bias are the biases that analysis of reviews can create. Voluntary response bias is innately an issue when working with reviews of an external source. Since the reviews I will be working with come from "getapp.com" and the reviews are optional, the reviews could be heavily saturated with people who have strong opinions of Discord and its features. This was mitigated through the restricting of the reviews to only 15 reviews within the last year and filtering out reviews without any detailed explanations about the reasonings. To combat confirmation bias, I purposely tried to keep an even amount of reviews on both the positive and negative side if possible so that I would be able to examine the reviews without simply focusing on my own opinions.

4 DATA INVENTORY

4.1 Who are the users?

From the observations of the needfinding exercises, this question can be answered through part of the survey. The survey directly asks the user about his

or her gender and age. A majority of the users tend to be male with an age range between 18 to 35 years old. Unfortunately, I believe that this question has only been partially answered since the survey did not ask the users of his or her level of expertise. Since the problem space is targeting novice users, this question should have been crucial in the survey. This is why I believe this question has failed in the current needfinding.

4.2 Where are the users?

The environment of the user observed in the participant observation needfinding. This needfinding was done in multiple different environments to allow me to experience what types of external factors will be affecting the user's experience with the interface. The users will be utilizing the interface more likely in a comfortable working environment such as their home or office.

4.3 What is the context of the task?

The needfinding exercise of participant observation was able to depict a clear context in which the user will be utilizing the interface. The user will be using the interface to communicate; however, the user will be in a situation where they will either be gaming, working, or studying as well. They will be using Discord to communicate with others to complete other goals. The users will be focused on other things that they would be doing as well, such as working out, playing a game, working, or even studying.

4.4 What are their goals?

The goals of the users can be determined in all of the needfinding exercises. The survey and analysis of the reviews gave clear data supporting the conclusion that the users' main goal is to use the interface for communication. With the participant observation, I personally experienced the use of the interface to communicate with others.

4.5 What do they need?

I believe that this question has been considered a failure. Although all three needfinding exercises implied that the user would require the basic necessities of a computer or mobile phone, this conclusion was not directly drawn from any of the needfinding, but from my own experience. Due to this fact, I believe that this question needs to be focused on in the next needfinding plan.

4.6 What are their tasks?

The participant observation allows me to draw specific conclusions to the tasks that the user will be doing. This includes typing into the computer, clicking with the mouse, tapping on the screen, and possibly even talking to others. Physically, the user will be sedentary while utilizing the interface, unless the user is using the mobile interface. Cognitively, the user will focus on following the correct steps into joining the voice channel he or she desires. Socially, the user will be interacting with other users after joining the call. To complete the goal, the user must go through all of these tasks.

4.7 What are their subtasks?

The subtasks the user will come across can be seen in both the participant observation and the survey. Throughout the procedural steps of the participant observation, the subtasks the user encounters are all laid out. The user must login into Discord to begin the application. Then the user must locate his or her desired voice channel and enter the channel. In the survey, a subtask that the responses mentioned was the audio and visual connections. The user must check for proper connection to the channel. To leave the channel after the conversation is completed the user must click on the leave channel button. All these subtasks require the user to either type or click on the proper buttons in the interface.

5 DEFINING REQUIREMENTS

The main requirements for this interface will be learnability. Since the application improvements will be targeting the novice users, learnability will be the goal to improve. Currently, the learnability of Discord's group voice channel is not as high as it can be. Most novice users struggle learning how to properly utilize this feature. Improving a new user's ability to learn the application will be the main criteria that must be met. A new user must be able to properly be able to complete the task of joining and leaving a voice call without any external assistance or extensive struggling in a certain amount of time for the interface to be considered a success. The application should be able to walk the user through its most prevalent feature without having the user becoming lost in the process.

6 NEEDFINDING CONTINUATION

With an additional phase of needfinding, the previously unanswered questions in the data inventory will now be addressed. Currently, the questions of "Who

are the users?" and "What do they need?" were not as clearly answered in the previous needfinding exercises. Although some parts of these questions were touched upon throughout the exercises, they were not explicitly addressed. Both of these questions will be greatly benefitted through "Think-aloud" and interviews. These exercises can help bolster the data to be collected in answering these two questions. Interviews will allow me to directly interact with the user and ask them questions to see his or her opinions on the task as well as more personalized data of who they are. Thinking aloud will also help analyze the user in what he or she needs in completing the task.

7 APPENDIX

7.1 Survey Raw Results

[Survey Link](#)